# The Objective Ledger

*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*



**The whole book** · Short version

All three parts: yourself, between us, and understanding people.

CHRISTIAN

# The Objective Ledger

THE WHOLE BOOK ON ONE PAGE

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*Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with*

THE WHOLE BOOK · SHORT VERSION



CHRISTIAN

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

*The Objective Ledger*: The whole book, the short version.
By Christian. Spread Love & Acceptance.

This edition: October 2026. Made from the chapters at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, where they are kept up to date.

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**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can’t know your situation.

**If you are not safe.** If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

**The examples are made up.** The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

# How to use this book

*This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 26 chapters in three parts, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.*

### THE PARTS

**Part One: Yourself.** Where you came from, who you are now and who you are becoming. You can read all of it on your own.

**Part Two: Between us.** One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

**Part Three: Understanding people.** How feelings, stress, trust, change, grief, groups and love work, for anyone, in any kind of relationship.

### TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

### READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

### IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

### THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the tools and worksheets the chapters mention. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

### GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

# The book in two pictures

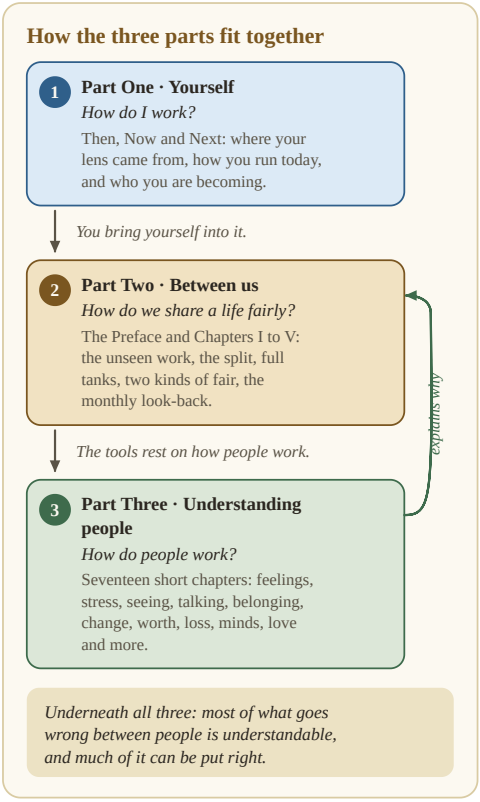



FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

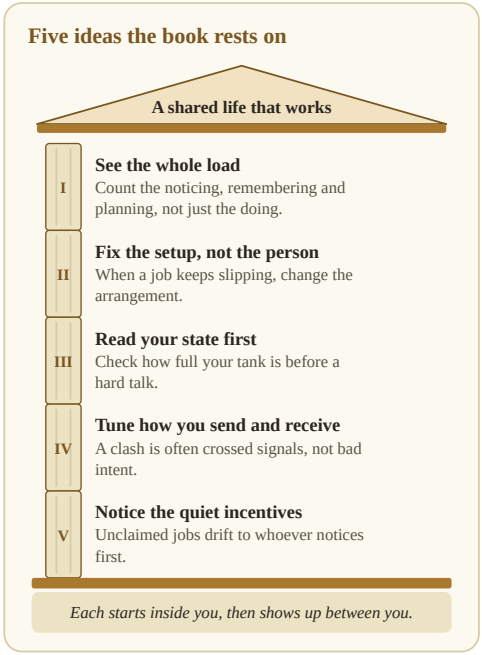



FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART TWO

# Between us

*One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.*



IN THIS PART

Chapter II Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home 9

# II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

# Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

*One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
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12. The fields behind this chapter
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14. Common mix-ups
15. If only one of you wants to try this
16. More for your situation


ANY GIVEN WEEK

*One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about. When the other one says it feels even, they mean it. From inside each person's own week, it does.*

01

## Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask “Is this working?”, the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Re-ask it every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

***For example:*** Two housemates had one awful week of dishes. The whole month showed three fine weeks and one exam week.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “Can we look at the whole month before we decide anything?”

> TRY THIS:
> Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.

02

## Three things go in.

How evenly the hours are shared. Whether every regular job has a clear owner (the job list, WP-03). And how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on.

A **workpaper** (the “WP” in WP-03) is one of the site’s free fill-in worksheets. You don’t need any of them to start. Rough notes on paper work too.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “Let’s each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess.”

> TRY THIS:
> Open the three worksheets once, just to see what they ask.

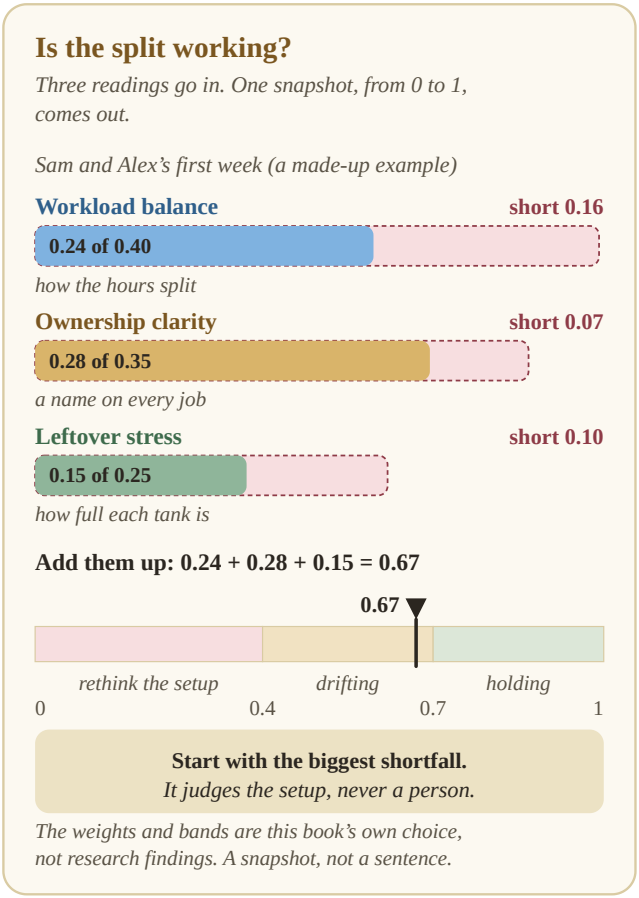



FIGURE 13 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

## Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1. One person doing everything scores 0. It doesn't matter which person is doing more. If you agreed an uneven split that suits you (say, one of you works longer hours outside the home), compare against that split instead.

***For example:*** Three partners log 30 hours of home jobs: 15, 9 and 6. An even share is 10 each.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not keeping score of you. I just want us both to see the hours."

TRY THIS:

Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes.

**Three or more of you?** Compare each person's share with an even share (100 ÷ number of people), or with a split you agreed. The Lemonade Stand, a free page where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

**The Lemonade Stand: quick look**

*Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)*

## Quick look: who does what at home

Tap who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
*Wren*

Their name
*Josh*

Person 3
*Mei*

| JOB | WHO MOSTLY DOES IT |
|---|---|
| *Dishes* | *Shared* |
| *Laundry* | *Shared* |
| *Cleaning the bathroom* | *Josh* |
| *Cooking dinner* | *Mei* |
| *Grocery shopping* | *Wren* |
| *Paying bills* | *Wren* |
| *Noticing what's running low* | *Wren* |
| *Planning the week* | *Mei* |
| *Remembering dates and appointments* | *Wren* |

### HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.*

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand quick look (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand.html)

04

## Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names: the owner, who does the job start to finish, and a backstop, who notices if it slipped and gently checks in (never a supervisor). It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have both names filled in, then divide by all the jobs on the list. Leave jobs nobody owns on the list. They are the ones that matter most.

***For example:*** Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his prescription, so each thought the other had ordered it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn't fall between us?"

TRY THIS:

Find one job with no name, and give it an owner and a backstop today.

05

## Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (WP-02). A higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate, and 0.60 or more is high. If either of you is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says. A setup that only works when you're both well rested isn't one that can last, so more stress lowers the result.

***For example:*** A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70. Her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"My tank is high this week. Can we plan around that, not around the average?"

TRY THIS:

Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other’s.

06

## One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

0.7 or above: the setup is holding. From 0.4 up to 0.7: something is drifting, often who owns what. Below 0.4: the setup needs a kind rethink. (The result is called the setup score. It looks like a probability, but it isn’t one. It’s a simple weighted sum.)

A **weighted sum** means each part counts for a set share: the hours count most, then the owners, then stress.

***For example:*** Two friends who run a café score 0.55. Nothing is broken, but something is drifting.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“This number is about our setup, not about us.”

TRY THIS:

Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

**Is the setup working for everyone?**

*Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years*

Is the setup working for everyone?

| Person 1 (optional) | Person 2 (optional) |
|---|---|
| *Rosemary* | *Ken* |

### 1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the Lemonade Stand: each person's total hours for the week.

| Rosemary, hours | Ken, hours |
|---|---|
| 14 | 10 |

### 2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

| Jobs on the list | Jobs with an owner |
|---|---|
| 12 | 9 |

### 3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

| Rosemary, battery (0 to 1) | Ken, battery (0 to 1) |
|---|---|
| 0.45 | 0.30 |

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

**Working well**

0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

What would help most: hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken. Balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00.

Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through). Ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.*

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick.html)

07

## Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. In the middle band that is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests WP-03 first. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add.

***For example:*** Separated parents score 0.62. Their biggest gap: nobody owns school forms. They fix only that.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

TRY THIS:

Choose one small change, not five.

08

### It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

***For example:*** One partner sees 0.35: "So I'm the problem." The other: "No. The bathroom has no owner, and you work nights."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Whatever this shows, I'm on your side."

> TRY THIS:
> Before you start, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back toward your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today

> SUNDAY EVENING
>
> *Two week-long logs and two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. Nobody says anything for a moment. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."*

## Words this chapter uses

- **Log:** a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took.
- **Owner:** the person who does a job from start to finish, including remembering it.

- **Backstop:** the person who notices if a job slipped and gently checks in. A helper, never a boss.
- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life.
- **Setup:** the way you share the work right now. It can always be changed.
- **Setup score:** one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. It describes the setup, never a person.

Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing the soap is running low are all work, even though nobody sees them happen. Put them in your log.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd like to add the thinking jobs to our list, like remembering and planning. They take time too."

## Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** See your own share honestly, from what you wrote down rather than from memory. See the way you share work as a setup you can redesign, not a flaw in you.
- **Between you and others:** Put both people's numbers on one page, and read the result as a note about the setup, never a verdict on a person. Clear owners leave less room for blame.

## On your own: is your own load working?

This chapter asks whether a shared setup can last. You can ask the same about your own week: are you spending more energy than comes back in?

- Add up what you carry: jobs, people and worries.
- Set it beside what refills you: rest, help, and people who give back.
- If it runs in the red, change your side: drop, delay, ask or say no kindly. A limit is a statement about supply, not about your worth.

*For example:* After a breakup, Dee has her kids every other week, and fills the quiet weeks with favors for friends. Writing it down showed her she never rests. More in On my own.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I’d love to help, and I can’t this week. Can I let you know next week?”

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write three things that drained you this week and one thing that refilled you.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 1: check your battery · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: matching energy · The whole book on sharing the load

## The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author’s thirteen fields (see the Preface or the About page). The first few:

- **Finance** (Pillar I): Like a small shop asking whether it can keep paying its bills, month after month. The chapter reads the setup that way, never as a verdict on the people.
- **Business** (Pillar II): Ownership clarity: one owner per job, borrowed from project work, and the maker-and-checker habit from internal controls. Every regular job gets a person who does it and a backstop who notices if it slipped.
- **Neurobiology** (Pillar III): Leftover stress: a quick self-rating of the stress you’re already carrying. It borrows the idea that stress builds up in the body, but it doesn’t measure your body.
- **Economics** (Pillar I): Limited capacity and the safety margin.

**Two fields, one idea: Business + Economics.** Unowned work falls to whoever notices first, every time. That’s what turns a fixable imbalance into a repeating one, so the check counts owners, not just the hours.

See how all the fields connect, in the full version · The polymath way

## In real life

- **Partners:** After a new baby arrives, the hours tip heavily one way without anyone deciding it. The check can show it before resentment builds.

- **Family:** Two siblings share care for a parent. One lives nearby and does most of the visits. Writing down the hours helps them rebalance in other ways, like paperwork and phone calls.
- **Roommates:** Everyone agrees cleaning matters, but nobody owns the bathroom. The ownership score shows the gap straight away.
- **Coworkers:** Two people share one role. The same three questions still work: how the hours split, who owns what, and how stretched each person is.
- **Two dads:** With no old script for who does what, nothing was decided. One of them quietly took on all the school messages.
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three or more, “someone will do it” often means nobody does. Owners matter even more. See More than two.
- **Foster and kinship carers:** Meetings, forms and contact visits are real work. See Foster and kinship families.
- **Shift workers:** Hours can look even while sleep is not. See Different hours.
- **When one of you is ill:** Share by energy, and agree an uneven split on purpose. See When one of you is ill.
- **Dorm roommates:** A room agreement with names next to jobs settles most of it. See Sharing a room.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “I think the way we split things worked before, and life changed. Can we look at it again together?”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

**Our room agreement**

*Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates*

## Our room agreement

Your name
*Kayla*

Their name
*Bea*

Quiet hours
*11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.*

Guests (daytime)
*Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.*

Overnight guests
*Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.*

Cleaning
*Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.*

Borrowing
*Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.*

Lights and alarms
*Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.*

How we bring up problems
*Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.*

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

*A made-up example. Names and details are invented. They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.*

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room.html)

## Common mix-ups

- **“A low number means the relationship is failing.”** It only means the current setup needs changing. Setups change all the time.
- **“A high number means nobody can complain.”** A good score never silences anyone. If something feels wrong, say so.
- **“We can just guess the numbers.”** A guessed number is really just a feeling with a decimal point. Use your written logs.
- **“Taking unowned jobs off the list will help.”** It raises the number and changes nothing at home.
- **“One of us can fill it in for both.”** Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank.
- **“Fair means exactly 50/50.”** Fair is what you both agree to, with eyes open. An uneven split you chose together can be fair. Chapter IV covers the kinds of fair.
- **“The backstop checks up on the owner.”** No. The backstop only notices if something slipped, and asks kindly. It is help, not a check on someone.

## If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week and score your own tank. Then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers.

*For example:* A dad noticed he spent five hours a week driving his teenage son around. He just said so, and they agreed a bus pass for two days a week. See Teens.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> “I tried writing down my week, just for me. Can I show you one thing I noticed?”

TRY THIS:
Share one finding, not the whole list. Then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

## More for your situation

Money together · Gaming and time together · Friends · Family rifts · Grown-up children · Grandparents · Co-parenting · Coming home · Empty nest · At work · For counselors

TRY THIS:

Each of you logs one week in WP-01, Who did what, first. The number only means something if you each wrote your own.

Next, fill in the job list in WP-03, One owner per job, together, including any jobs nobody owns yet.

Then each of you scores how full your own stress tank is in WP-02, How much are you carrying?, on the same day.

Put the three numbers into the calculator. Look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together, and check again in a month.

Then see if the load can last (CALC-01) → The full calculator →

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Look at the month, not last night.
- ✓ Balance: how the hours split.
- ✓ Stress: how full each stress tank is.
- ✓ One number comes out, from 0 to 1.
- ✓ It judges the setup, never a person.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees**
*The unseen work the check counts*
online

**Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress input, explained* online

**Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change**
*Fixing the setup with small, kind changes* online

**Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well**
*When one person carries the care* online

PUT IT TO USE

**Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01.html#week-2

**One owner per job**
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job.html

# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### A bid

A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

*For example: They show you a photo of a dog. Looking and smiling back is turning toward it.*

### A kind no

A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

*For example: "I can't take that on this week. I could help on Saturday."*

### Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" (WP-02) measures the other side of it, your load: a higher WP-02 score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

*For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your load score is high and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.*

### Calm-Down Kit

The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

*For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.*

### Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

*For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.*

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

*For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"*

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

*For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.*

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

*For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.*

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

*For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"*

### Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

*For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.*

### Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

*For example: Forcing eye contact and rehearsing small talk all day, then needing the evening to recover.*

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

*For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.*

### Pressure

Pressure is the number in Today's Weather that shows how much is pressing on you today. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

*For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.*

### Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

*For example: "I said that badly. What I meant was..."*

### Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

*For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."*

### Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

*For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.*

### Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

*For example: Your window says "wait," so you ask to talk after dinner instead of right now.*

### The Five Pillars

The Five Pillars are the five ideas under everything here: see the whole load, fix the setup, read your state first, tune how you send and receive, and notice the quiet incentives.

*For example: A chip near the top of each page shows which pillars that page uses.*

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

*For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.*

### The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

*For example: "Whoever notices the mess cleans it" was the rule at home, so a messy kitchen feels like "It's always me."*

### Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

*For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.*

### Turning toward

Turning toward means answering someone's small bids for attention, even briefly, instead of missing or brushing them off.

*For example: "Oh, that's a funny one!" instead of scrolling on.*

### Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

*For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.*

### Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

*For example: A hint like "the bins are full" may be heard as a plain fact, not a request.*

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

*For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.*

### Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

*For example: WP-01 is a week's log of who did what.*

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

*For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.*

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# Research notes

*The 397 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Every entry was checked against the original source. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.*

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

## Is the split working?

**Daminger, A. (2019).** *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labor": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

**Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968).** *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Students who heard another participant apparently having a seizure over an intercom were slower and less likely to report it when they believed other listeners were present, showing diffusion of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

**di Leonardo, M. (1987).** *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

**Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975).** *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

**Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989).** *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com/books/310593/the-second-shift-by-arlie-hochschild

**Kurdek, L. A. (2007).** *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

**Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979).** *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

**Strathern, M. (1997).** *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org/core/journals/european-review/article/improving-ratings-audit-in-the-british-university-system/FC2EE640C0C44E3DB87C29FB666E9AAB

**U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau) (None).** *American Time Use Survey (ATUS), annual since 2003.* The federal survey of how, where and with whom Americans spend their time, including unpaid housework and childcare; it has run every year since 2003.
`census.gov/programs-surveys/atus.html`

**Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015).** *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
`pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4584401`

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*Key ideas and the pages where the book talks about them. Chapter names are in the contents.*


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A calm, practical book about the quiet work of sharing a life. It starts with you: where your lens came from, how you work today and who you are becoming. Then it looks at what happens between people who share a home, work or care. And it ends with how people work: feelings, stress, trust, change, loss, anger, love and the groups we belong to.

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